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“OUR VISION IS TO CREATE A DIGITAL SCIENTIFIC ARMY”

Eli Lilly Chair and CEO David A. Ricks on the Indian pharma sector and the use of technology

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GLOBAL PHARMA

major Eli Lilly is ramping up its presence in India. Leading Eli Lilly—that has been around for nearly 150 years and had posted revenues of \$34.12 billion in 2023—is David A. Ricks, 54, who has been with the company for more than 25 years. In an exclusive interview with *Business Today* during a recent visit to India, the Chair and Chief Executive Officer of Eli Lilly and Company discusses the challenges for large companies entering the Indian market, recommendations for the pharma sector, and the use of AI in pharma, among other things. Edited excerpts:

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What are the developments coming out of your capability centre

in India?

Lilly operates two businesses in India: Eli Lilly and Company (India) Pvt. Ltd, which supplies innovative pharmaceutical products in the country, and the global capability centre (Eli Lilly Services India Pvt. Ltd in Bengaluru), which is a cross-functional centre that leverages data, content, analytics, and technology to support the global drug development process. The centre boasts a large group of over 3,000 people. It was established eight years ago, and since then, it has experienced rapid growth... Now, our colleagues at the centre collaborate with teams worldwide to enhance capacity and accelerate processes, ensuring efficient progress in our clinical trials.

Additionally, we have developed a substantial tech group at the centre, focussed on supporting our global technology initiatives and exploring innovative technologies like AI. There's also a marketing team dedicated to digital marketing strategies, contributing to our global marketing efforts. Alongside, we offer core services as well. Overall, the centre has been a tremendous success.

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How does the India capability centre contribute to R&D globally?

It contributes in many ways. Initially, it was for expanding work capacity [for clinical trials], but now we have seen several examples of true innovation. One of the more

interesting ones we are utilising, and this is India's special opportunity, is in biopharma, involving the fusion of technology and biotechnology. We observed some very clever work by computer scientists in Bengaluru who are modelling experiments in silico (the process examines hypothetical results of computer models to test new and improve existing drugs) to collaborate with their colleagues in wet labs (where experiments are performed) in other parts of the world, thereby saving experimentation time and speeding up the work. That was very exciting to see. India could play a significant role for us in that regard.

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How do you perceive the